

From Homemaker to Entrepreneur: Suman's Journey of Growth and Confidence

"Through the support of her Self Help Group, continuous learning, and determination, Suman transformed herself from a homemaker into a confident entrepreneur and community leader

Background

Suman, a resident of Matnali village in Himachal Pradesh, never imagined that one day she would become an entrepreneur, a community leader, and an inspiration for other rural women. Today, she is associated with the Shiv Shakti Self Help Group (SHG) and serves as the President of her Village Organization (Gram Sangathan). However, just a few years ago, her life



was very different.

Before Suman joined the Self Help Group in 2021, She stayed at home. Took care of her family. Suman rarely went outside her home. She lived in a village and did not meet many people outside of her family. Suman remembers that she did not know the women who lived near her. She was not confident to talk to others.

Reflecting on those days, she says:

"मैं गृहिणी थी। मुझे किसी से बात करने में भी झिझक होती थी। अपने ही वार्ड की महिलाओं को नहीं जानती थी। 26 साल बाद मैंने पहली बार फिर से

पेन पकड़ा।"

Joining the Self Help Group became the turning point in her life. Through regular meetings and community interactions, she gradually became more confident, improved her communication skills, and started participating in decisions that affected her family and community.

The Entrepreneurial Journey

For Suman starting a business was not about earning money it was about supporting her family and creating a better future, for her children.

She knew that it was getting really tough to depend on one income. Her children were going to college so Suman wanted to help out with the expenses and make the most of the things she already had around her.

"एक व्यक्ति की कमाई से घर चलाना आसान नहीं था। मैंने सोचा कि अगर मैं भी कुछ करूँ, तो परिवार की जिम्मेदारियाँ मिलकर निभा पाएँगे।"

She first started with tailoring, sewing women's suits from her home. As more women in the neighbourhood liked her work she began getting sewing orders.

Of stopping there Suman kept looking for new ways to earn a living. She slowly moved into dairy farming, buying two cows with a loan from the bank after learning about it through the Self Help Group. Now she sells milk and makes about 6 kilograms of pure desi ghee each month which is bought by people not just in Himachal Pradesh but also from Gujarat through personal connections.

Happy, with this growth she added more to her business by making pickles, jams and chutneys using fruits and vegetables from her own land.

Unlike small businesses that use materials they buy most of Suman's products are made with things grown on her farm like amla, galgal, lemon, ginger, chillies, peaches, plums, apricots and apples. She only buys things like spices, salt, oil and packaging from the market.

Business Growth

What is really great, about Suman's journey is that she is always eager to learn things and try new ideas. She did not just rely on one way of making money Instead she slowly started doing different things to earn a living. Now Suman is successfully doing things at the same time. She is tailoring, dairy farming making ghee and processing food at different times of the year. She is doing all of this while taking care of her home and family.

She says that each business she started was built one step at a time. Suman started with tailoring then she moved on to dairy farming. After that she began making pickles, jams and chutneys. She was able to do this because she had quality ingredients right on her own farm.

Although managing multiple enterprises alone is challenging, she personally handles almost every stage of production—from harvesting raw materials and preparing recipes to packaging and labelling products.

"अचार, जैम और चटनी का लगभग पूरा काम मैं खुद करती हूँ। कटाई से लेकर पैकिंग तक हर काम में समय और मेहनत लगती है, लेकिन यही मेरे व्यवसाय की पहचान है।"

Suman puts the name of the Self Help Group on her products. She also puts the ingredients. How she keeps them fresh on the labels. This shows that Suman really cares about making products and being honest with her customers.

Suman has a lot of work to do. She still wants to make her food business bigger. She thinks that if more women from the Self Help Group help her they can make food, sell it to more people and help many women in the country have a steady income, from the Self Help Group.

"अगर मेरी दीदियाँ मेरे साथ जुड़ जाएँ, तो मैं इस काम को बड़े स्तर पर ले जाना चाहती हूँ। अकेले सब कुछ करना मुश्किल है, लेकिन मिलकर हम बहुत आगे जा सकते हैं।"

Learning Through the IIT Delhi Training

Suman had already started a lot of things to earn a living. She thinks that every entrepreneur should keep learning and getting better. When she took part in the Entrepreneurship Development Programme at IIT Delhi, she got some ideas. These ideas were about how small businesses in areas can be more organised and sustainable. They can also learn how to sell their products in the market. Suman thinks this is very important for the Entrepreneurship Development Programme. The programme at IIT Delhi helped her learn more about how small rural enterprises, like hers can do.

Sharing her experience, she says:

"मैंने पहले भी कई प्रशिक्षण लिए हैं, लेकिन हर प्रशिक्षण से कुछ नया सीखने को मिलता है। इस प्रशिक्षण ने मुझे यह समझाया कि अगर हमें अपने व्यवसाय को आगे बढ़ाना है, तो हमें समय के साथ नए तरीकों को अपनाना भी ज़रूरी है।"

She found out that digital platforms are really helpful for business growth. Before this she mostly sold her products at exhibitions and to people she knew. The training taught her that digital tools can help people who start their businesses, show their products to more people, talk to a lot of customers and find new chances to sell outside of where they live. Digital platforms can really support the growth of her business. She learned that digital tools are very useful for entrepreneurs like her. She learned that digital platforms are important, for business growth. She explains:

"अब मुझे समझ आया है कि अगर हम अपने उत्पादों को डिजिटल माध्यमों से लोगों तक पहुँचाएँ, तो हमारे लिए नए ग्राहक और नए बाज़ार खुल सकते हैं। मैं धीरे-धीरे इन माध्यमों का उपयोग करना सीखना चाहती हूँ।"

The sessions on **financial literacy** also gave her a new perspective on managing a business. While she had always focused on producing quality products, she realised that maintaining proper records of income, expenses, production costs, and profits is equally important for business planning and long-term sustainability.

"पहले मैं केवल काम करने पर ध्यान देती थी, लेकिन अब मुझे लगता है कि आय, खर्च और लाभ का सही हिसाब रखना भी उतना ही ज़रूरी है। इससे मुझे अपने व्यवसाय को और बेहतर तरीके से आगे बढ़ाने में मदद मिलेगी।"

Another important learning for her was the importance of branding, packaging, and presenting products professionally. She believes that even high-quality products need proper presentation to build customer confidence and compete in larger markets.

Applying the Learnings in the Business

Suman is now focused, on using what she has learned to make her business stronger. She wants to make her products look better by improving the way they are wrapped and displayed. She will also keep her money records in order. She plans to start using online tools to talk to her customers in a better way.

She also wants to make pickles, jams, chutneys, dairy products and offer more tailoring services. She wants to get women from her Self Help Group involved in this work.

Looking Ahead

Suman believes that learning never ends. She wants to continue improving her products, strengthen her market presence, and gradually reach customers beyond her local area. More importantly, she dreams of building a larger women-led enterprise where every member of her Self Help Group can contribute, earn, and grow together. She believes that every woman has the potential to become financially independent if she is given the right opportunity, guidance, and encouragement.

"महिलाओं को कभी यह नहीं सोचना चाहिए कि वे कुछ नहीं कर सकतीं। शुरुआत छोटी हो सकती है, लेकिन मेहनत और सीखने की इच्छा हमें बहुत आगे ले जा सकती है।"